

STAGE SIXTEEN • WORKPLACE PROFESSIONALISM & ETHICS

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Sixteen • Workplace Professionalism & Workplace Readiness / Professional Ethics & Integrity

PURPOSE

Stage Sixteen's forty-five FIRSTS are written for solo reflection — observe your own norms, audit your own reputation, analyze your own ethical dilemma. But several of the workplace situations and ethical questions in this stage genuinely benefit from hearing how other people would navigate the same moment, since professionalism and ethics are both fundamentally social — what counts as appropriate or right is partly defined by how others actually respond.

This document adapts eight FIRSTS across all five sections of Stage Sixteen into pair, small-group, or structured-debate formats. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual reflection first, and the group version tests or deepens it.

A genuine caution specific to Sections 4 and 5: several of these FIRSTS touch real ethical vulnerability (an actual shortcut considered, real pressure faced). Every group adaptation below is designed to stay at an appropriate stakes level for a workshop setting — using hypothetical or anonymized scenarios rather than asking participants to confess real personal ethical lapses to the group.

The Eight Adapted Exercises

FIRST T3

Workplace Etiquette Awareness — Norm Detective Panel

TIME: +15 min beyond solo observation

1. Small groups of 3–4 share one genuine workplace norm each has observed that differed from a prior context.
2. The group tries to guess, before being told, what the person's prior context might have been based on the contrast described.
3. Debrief: which norms surprised the group most?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Hearing multiple genuinely different norm-transfer stories in one sitting reinforces that no single set of workplace norms is universal — useful before participants finalize their own individual reflection.

FIRST T12

Professional Boundary — Boundary Script Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Each participant drafts the specific language they'd use to state their boundary, individually first.
2. In pairs, read your draft aloud to a partner, who plays the role of the person receiving it and reacts genuinely.
3. Partner gives one piece of feedback: did it land as calm and professional, or as either apologetic or harsh?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Boundaries often sound different out loud than they do on paper — hearing a partner's genuine reaction is a fast, low-stakes way to calibrate tone before the real conversation happens.

FIRST T16

Workplace Accountability Conversation — Rehearsal Pairs

TIME: +15 min beyond solo planning

1. After identifying a real missed responsibility (their own or a peer's), pair participants up with a stand-in partner, not the actual person involved.
2. Partner A rehearses opening the conversation; Partner B responds as they'd genuinely expect the real person to.
3. Partner B steps out of role and gives one honest reaction: did that opening feel likely to focus on a path forward, or drift into blame?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Rehearsing the actual opening line out loud, even hypothetically, meaningfully lowers the barrier to having the real conversation. Keep this explicitly hypothetical — no real names or private details.

FIRST T22

Professional Reputation Audit — Simultaneous Reveal

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Groups of 4. Each person privately writes the one word they believe colleagues would use to describe their reliability.
2. All words are revealed simultaneously (written on cards, or shared on screen at once) — not spoken aloud in sequence.
3. Discuss as a group: how did self-perception compare to what participants guessed others might say?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Simultaneous reveal prevents anchoring to the first answer given, producing more genuine, independent responses — the same structural logic as the alignment-check exercises used in earlier stages.

FIRST T23

Workplace Culture Analysis — Stated vs. Observed Sort

TIME: +15 min beyond individual observation

1. Small groups list their organizations' stated values (from a website, handbook, or onboarding materials) on one side of a shared sheet.
2. On the other side, each person adds one specific, observed behavior that either confirms or contradicts a stated value.
3. Discuss: which gaps, if any, showed up across multiple people's organizations?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Seeing genuine gaps between stated and observed culture across several real organizations normalizes that this is common, not a sign any one workplace is uniquely dysfunctional.

FIRST T27

Integrity Decision — Silent Case Sort

TIME: +15 min beyond individual reflection

1. Present the group with 3–4 brief, anonymized hypothetical scenarios involving a genuine ethical shortcut.
2. Individually, each person marks whether they believe most people would take the shortcut, and whether they personally would.
3. In small groups, compare answers without judgment — discuss what made the “most people” and “personally” answers converge or diverge.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Separating “what most people would do” from “what I would do” surfaces genuine self-awareness about social pressure without requiring anyone to confess a real personal shortcut.

FIRST T35

Ethical Dilemma Analysis — Competing Values Debate

TIME: +20 min beyond individual analysis

1. Small groups take one real (anonymized) or hypothetical ethical dilemma with two genuinely defensible sides.
2. Split the group in two; each half argues for one side's competing value, even if it's not their personal view.
3. After both sides present, the group drops the assigned positions and discusses what a genuinely reasoned resolution might look like.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Arguing a position you don't personally hold is a genuinely effective way to surface the real weight of competing values, rather than defaulting to whichever side feels immediately comfortable.

FIRST T42

Speak-Up Awareness — Channel Mapping Exchange

TIME: +15 min beyond individual research

1. Each participant researches their own organization's speak-up channels individually first.
2. In small groups, compare what each organization offers — a hotline, HR, a direct manager, an ombudsperson.
3. Discuss: which approach seems like it would feel safest to actually use, and why?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Comparing real channels across different organizations helps participants evaluate their own organization's approach against genuine alternatives, rather than assuming their default option is the only or best one.